

User Guide to the Really Great Reading Digital Sound-Spelling Wall

Welcome to *Really Great Reading's* brand-new *Digital Sound-Spelling Wall*! This resource will provide a wide range of opportunities for your students to discover connections between the sounds we hear in speech and the words we see in print. While typical sound walls include a picture of a guideword that begins with a given speech sound (phoneme) along with the letter(s) (grapheme) that usually represents that sound, the *Really Great Reading Sound-Spelling Wall* also provides:

- a phoneme's most common spelling pattern highlighted in the context of the printed guideword, followed by additional spellings (each highlighted in a printed word and supported by a picture icon);
- pictures displaying correct mouth postures along with articulation tips provided through lines indicating airflow and voicing.

Sound Wall vs. Word Wall

The use of "Word Walls" was popular in the past, but now we know they are not an effective tool for teaching students to read words accurately and proficiently. In contrast, a "Sound Wall" (and even more so, a *"Sound-Spelling Wall"*) can be a highly effective component of structured literacy instruction. To learn some key differences, see the table below:

Word Walls	Sound Walls
• use a "print-to-speech" approach	• use a "speech-to-print" approach
• take a teacher's perspective (previous knowledge of the spellings of sounds)	• take a student's perspective (discover knowledge of the spellings of sounds)
• consist of single letters; usually arranged in alphabetical order; followed by words beginning with the featured letter rather than sound (may have supporting pictures)	• consist of images representing a single "phoneme" (speech sound), such as pictures of items starting with the sound; usually arranged by articulation features; followed by "graphemes" (one or more letters that spell a phoneme) and sometimes printed words
• sounds in words may be inconsistent ("s" in "sun" does not sound like "s" in "she"; "know" does not start with the sound /k/)	• images and printed words consistently contain the featured phoneme; common spellings are displayed
• learning is limited to the words presented; words may change over time (cycle in or out)	• learning is unlimited as mastered skills can be applied to countless new words

Effective use of the *Sound-Spelling Wall* can promote increased student awareness of how reading and writing are grounded in speaking and provide students with the ability to "self-teach" (or discover) new words by applying knowledge of learned (not memorized) patterns, structures, and strategies. This resource supports your students in speaking, reading, and spelling, resulting in greater student independence in reading and writing throughout the day!

Why use a Sound-Spelling Wall to support student learning?

Learning to speak is natural and is learned by repeated exposure to spoken language. Reading is not learned by immersion in print. It must be explicitly taught. This speech-to-print resource provides opportunities for direct, explicit teaching and modeling of foundational phonological skills so that students can gradually become more independent learners. Over time, they will be able to make observations about what they hear, see, and feel; to describe what they've observed; and then to organize this information and apply it to new learning. Lessons addressing these critical skills (observing, describing, categorizing, and understanding concepts such as 1:1 correspondence, same/different, and first/next/last) are addressed in Really Great Reading's *Launchpad* and *Countdown* programs.

Skill development supported by use of the Sound-Spelling Wall

For students to get the most out of the *Sound-Spelling Wall*, it is important for students to understand that spoken words are made up of a sequence of sounds (phonemes); that these individual sounds can be isolated; and that these sounds can be distinguished from one another. These early phonemic awareness skills provide a framework for understanding the alphabetic principle (letters represent speech sounds) and phonics.

Lessons addressing skills such as sound isolation, sound blending, and sound segmentation are taught and practiced throughout the *Launchpad*, *Countdown*, *Blast*, and *HD Word* programs.

As part of a structured, sequential, explicit, and multisensory literacy approach, the *Sound-Spelling Wall* supports continued development of the following critical skills:

Goal	Skills needed	Supporting Sound-Spelling Wall Components
Correct sound articulation and perception	Use sensory feedback to correctly produce sounds; use this ability to identify phonemes by their spoken features	- Mouth pictures show place of production and posture of <i>articulators</i> (lips, tongue) - Mouth pictures include various lines that indicate voicing and airflow
Increased phonemic awareness	- Recognize isolated phonemes by spoken features to differentiate between them - Identify phonemes in words; segment, blend, and manipulate sequences of sounds	Visual portrayal of phoneme production features allows for identification of isolated sounds using multisensory cues
Understanding the alphabetic principle	1:1 correspondence between phonemes and graphemes - Knowledge that these relationships are fairly consistent and predictable	- Presentation of the most common spelling of a phoneme within a printed word - Examples of alternative spellings, also in the context of printed words
Increased orthographic knowledge	Decoding and encoding words using a specific sequence of phonemes connected to a matching sequence of graphemes	- Individual phoneme cards can be arranged to match a specific sequence of sounds, revealing the correct spellings of words * Physical cards only (see p. 6)

Basic Vowel Valley

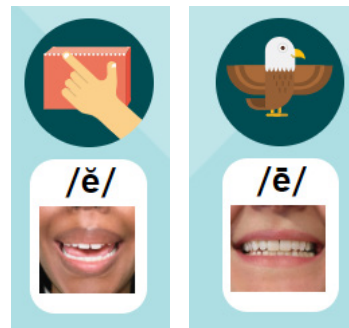
The *Really Great Reading Sound-Spelling Wall* includes sound and spelling information on 19 vowel phonemes and 26 consonant phonemes.

Vowels are a class of phoneme defined by airflow that is not restricted as it moves through the vocal tract. All vowels are continuous (“stretchy”) and voiced (“noisy”), changing only by the shape of the mouth. These similarities make it especially difficult for students to discriminate between vowel sounds.

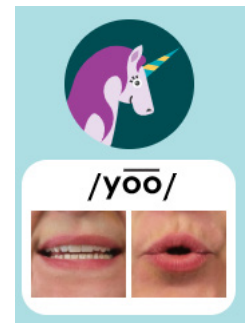
Vowel phonemes are presented in a “vowel valley” formation according to the openness of the mouth when the phoneme is articulated. Each phoneme is initially represented by a guideword icon. The icon correlates with the guidewords utilized in Really Great Reading’s *Launchpad*, *Countdown*, *Blast*, and *HD Word* programs. Most of the guidewords **begin** with the target phoneme. The few exceptions are **book**, **bird**, **barn**, and **fork**.



Sound boxes for vowel phonemes show the vowel phoneme with one of two diacritical marks. The breve (ĕ) indicates a short vowel phoneme, and the macron (ē) indicates a long vowel phoneme.



Phonemes that are diphthongs, when the mouth changes shape during articulation, include two mouth images below the icon to show the beginning mouth shape and the end mouth shape. These phonemes are placed outside of the “Vowel Valley” arc.

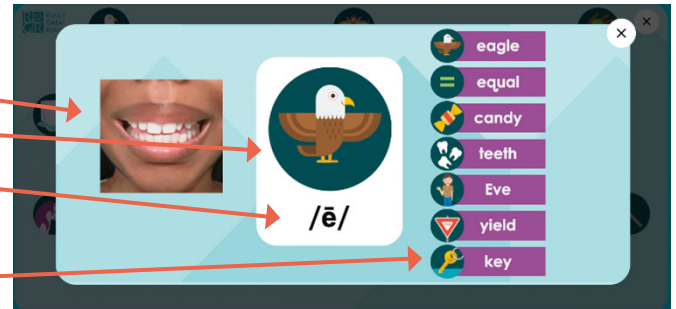


The Basic Vowel Valley is a *sound wall*. Each vowel sound is represented by an icon, a sound box, and a mouth formation picture. No spellings are present in the Basic Vowel Valley. Clicking on an icon reveals a white card that includes both a sound box, which shows a symbolic representation of the phoneme, and a mouth picture showing proper mouth formation. A second click closes the card below an icon. Any number of sound cards can be open at any given time. Icons can also be tabbed through using the Tab key, and the sound box/mouth picture cards can be opened and closed using the Enter key.

Advanced Vowel Valley

The Advanced Vowel Valley is a *sound-spelling wall*. Initially, the screen looks the same as the Basic Vowel Valley. However, rather than seeing a small card with the above-mentioned information, clicking on an icon displays one much larger card with the following information:

1. mouth formation picture
2. guideword icon
3. sound box (pronunciation key)
4. most common spellings for the target phoneme shown in a common word and with an icon depicting that word



Consonant Canyon

Consonants are a class of phoneme defined by airflow that is restricted, or even stopped, as it moves through the vocal tract. Consonants are generally easier for students to discriminate between because they can vary by several features:

- place of production: location of articulator contact or restriction (lips, tongue, teeth, throat)
- voice: voiced (noisy) or unvoiced (quiet)
- manner of production: variation in the airflow *duration* (a quick *stop consonant* as in /b/ or a stretchy *fricative consonant* as in /s/) and airflow *force* (pushed as in /ch/ or leaky as in /l/)

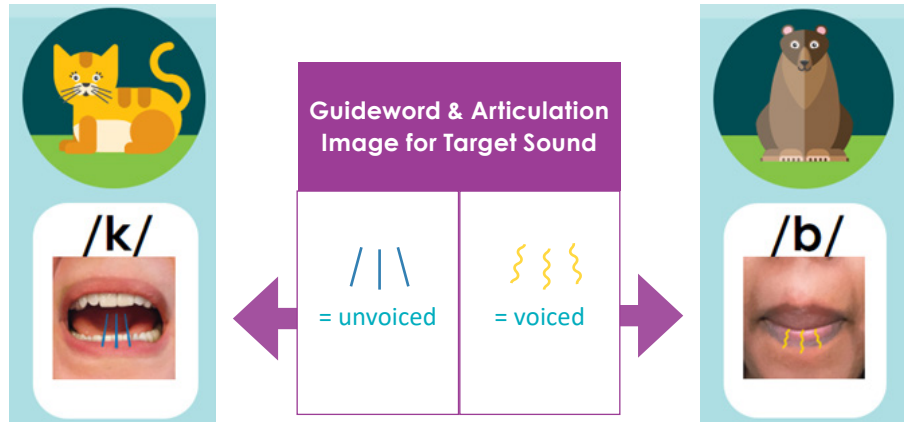
The teacher can highlight these differences (“*What did you feel or see your mouth do? Was the sound quick or stretchy? Was your voice turned on?*”) while modeling consonant phonemes. The use of mirrors can be beneficial for students when learning consonants.

Consonant phonemes are displayed in alphabetical order, with unique digraph and other consonant phonemes at the bottom, to make it quick and easy to find the phoneme of interest. With one exception, the guidewords **begin** with the target phoneme. The exception is the word **fox**, representing the most common sound of the letter **x**, /ks/. As this sound does not exist for this spelling at the beginning of words, it is more appropriate to use a word where the most common sound is represented accurately.



Consonant Mouth Pictures

Each consonant phoneme mouth picture includes either voice or breath lines to indicate voiced and unvoiced consonants and placement of articulation. Yellow lines indicate voiced phonemes, and blue lines indicate unvoiced phonemes.



The chart below shows how particular consonant sounds are similar in two ways, by *place* of production and by *manner* of production.

Place of production:			
Lip Sounds	Teeth Sounds	Tongue Sounds	Throat Sounds
(bilabial: 2 lips) p, b m w	(labiodental: lip/teeth) f, v (interdental: tongue teeth) th, th	(alveolar: front) t, d, s, z, n, l (palatal: middle) sh, zh, ch, j, r (velar: back) k, g, ng	(glottal: throat) h
Manner of production:			
Quick Sounds	Stretchy Sounds	Pushed Sounds	Glide Sounds
(stops) p, b t, d k, g	(fricatives) f, v s, z sh, zh th, th h	(affricates) ch, j	(glides) y, w
		Nose Sounds	Flow Sounds
		(nasals) m, n, ng	(liquids / laterals) r, l

Printable Cards Option

In addition to the *Sound-Spelling Wall*, Really Great Reading is excited to offer printable *Sound-Spelling Cards* for users of our foundational literacy skills programs. This printable resource is accessible in the Instructional Resources area of the Supply Room of *Countdown Online*, *Blast Online*, and *HD Word Online* under “Interactive Resources” and also under “Posters, Other.” See the user’s guide in that section for specific information on the cards.

Handwriting samples modeling accurate letter formation and line placement (physical cards only).

